

HISTORY AND CULTURAL HERITAGE OF ISTANBUL

week5

Architecture in Constantinople (Roman and Byzantine period)

MILITARY ARCHITECTURE

City Walls



Architecture in Constantinople (Roman and Byzantine period)

CIVIL ARCHITECTURE

- Hippodrome
- Palaces
- Ports
- Water structures (Aqueduct and cistern)
- Square-obelisks

RELIGIOUS ARCHITECTURE (Byzantine Period)

- In Istanbul, where there are more than 500 churches known from sources and built in different periods, a large portion of the structures representing the religious architecture of the Byzantine period are **monastery churches**.
- Since their purpose of establishment was to distance themselves from worldly affairs and to worship, **monasteries** were **established in the countryside**, **in places far from settlements, and due to changing conditions, they were also established in settlements in order to guarantee the lives of the ruling class in old age or after a political change that could result in their disadvantage.**
- Monastery churches are **the best-preserved representatives of religious architecture** because they are made of more careful and durable materials than the secondary structures located in the monastery they belong to and because they have been repaired and used for centuries.
- In addition**, congregational churches** *(cemaat)* such as Hagia Sophia and Hagia Irene are **the most important representatives of religious architecture** because they have **remained in continuous use despite their changing functions**.

Christianity

- Christianity's real development took place in Europe; Gentile Christianity, led by Paul, began to spread rapidly **among peasants and slaves in Europe** from the middle of the first century AD. The reason for this was that the doctrine of salvation in Christianity attracted the attention of these oppressed classes.
- Those from **the upper classes** who accepted Christianity took the leading role in the spread of the new religion by using the advantages of being Roman citizens.
- Despite all these developments, Christianity continued to be an underground movement until the fourth century.
- **Christianity, which began to disrupt the social structure of the Roman Empire with its discourse of brotherhood and equality from the time it was widely accepted**, experienced its first major persecution during Nero's reign (54-68). The hatred and persecution campaigns that began with Nero further strengthened Christianity. Christianity became an organized movement from the time of Nero.
- Titus Flavius Domitianus, who ascended to the Roman throne, accelerated the extermination operation against Christians together with the Jews. Decius, who became emperor of Rome in 249, demanded that all Christians offer sacrifices in the name of the emperor in order to strengthen the official state cult. The forced conversion of Christians to Roman religion was only partially successful, and some communities became or appeared to become pagans.

The first Roman emperor to be a Christian and to take Christianity under state protection was Constantine.

- Constantine, who was declared emperor in 306, granted freedom to Christians living in his lands with the Milan Edict he published in 313. Constantine, who declared Istanbul as the New Rome, intended to use the Christian population that was rapidly spreading and becoming strong in his lands for his political goals.

- Because in the 4th century, a large part of Southern Europe, Anatolia and North Africa had become Christian. From this century onwards, the threat of the Germanic tribes that began to descend from the north to the south could be prevented with a power that would unite the empire, and at this point, the importance of Christianity, which declared war on paganism, was indisputable. The Christian population increased rapidly with the activities carried out by Gregory the Great among the Armenians who formed the eastern border of the empire; Armenian King Tridates was the first king to accept Christianity.

- **When Constantine made Istanbul the capital of the Eastern Roman Empire, Istanbul also became one of the important church centers.**

The first emperor to recognize Christianity *as the official religion of the Roman State* was Theodosius I.

Theodosius, who was baptized in 380, also opposed heretical movements such as Arianism and wanted to homogenize Christianity in the empire. The same tendency towards institutionalization continued during the reign of his grandson Theodosius II.

- Starting with Constantine and ending with the death of Theodosius II in 450, the struggles against the numerous sects that emerged as Christianity became official in both Western and Eastern Roman lands constituted the main issue.
- The period from Constantine to Pope Gregory I is known as a period when Christianity began to spread rapidly. This process is also the harbinger of some developments within Christianity, most of which were aimed at sectarian conflicts.

- **The division of Rome into two main geographies, Eastern and Western**, from the 4th century onwards, in a sense **determined the fate of Christianity**. **After this date, Christianity in the West remained loyal to its Latin roots and shaped the geography of Europe, while Eastern Christianity, centered in Istanbul, embraced the Greek heritage and formed Christianity in the geography of Anatolia.**
- The 4th century also provided the source for the intellectual development of local churches that benefited from state patronage and the schisms that would lead to sectarian conflicts..

- **The year 1054 is an important turning point marking the separation of the Catholic and Orthodox churches.**
  - From this date on, *the Orthodox church was represented by the Byzantine Empire* **until the fourteenth and fifteenth centuries.** After the conquest of Istanbul by the Turks, the country that continued the same mission became Russia as the "third Rome".

In the period from the 11th century to the end of the 13th century, Christianity faced two important issues:

the separation of the Orthodox and **Catholic churches**,
and
the Crusades.

The main events that caused the church in Byzantine lands to separate from the Roman church under the name of the Orthodox church can be listed as follows:

- **Different cultural grounds.** The geography surrounded by Byzantine lands had been distant from Latin Europe since the Hellenistic period and was structured on Greek heritage. In the Middle East, especially in Anatolia, which was under Greek influence, the fact that the language of worship was Greek created a sufficient separation from the Latin liturgy. Although the church had tried to eliminate this separation since the 4th century, it could not succeed.

- **State control of the church in the East.** As a tradition that started with Constantine, emperors in Byzantium tried to direct the future of the church. Especially during the problems of iconoclasm, the emperors' taking precautions against the people's respect for icons led to a reaction from the church in Rome, and Rome interpreted this incident as state intervention in the church.

- **Charlemagne declared emperor by the pope.** Pope Leo III's declaration of Charlemagne as the king of Christianity in 800 disturbed Byzantium. Because Charlemagne's undertaking of Christian missionary work meant that the northern peoples were Christianized by Rome.

- **When disagreements arose between the Western and Eastern churches regarding mission activities** to the Slavic peoples, Photios, the Patriarch of Constantinople, issued a church declaration condemning some Latin beliefs and practices, which further exacerbated the disagreement between the two churches. Photios also criticized Rome's emphasis on celibacy by attributing it to the Manichaean influence in the church (the Manichaeans, a heterodox Christian group, argued that priests who were the administrators of the church should not marry).

- **The Pope's attempt to forcibly Latinize the Greek church traditions in Southern Italy**. Following Rome's stance, Patriarch of Constantinople Michael Cerularius closed the Latin churches in Istanbul. Cardinal Humbert also came from Italy and left an excommunication on the altar of Hagia Sophia in Istanbul (June 16, 1054). This declaration excommunicated Patriarch Cerularius, the Greek doctrine of the Holy Spirit, and the marriage of Greek priests.

Latin Invasion (1204-1261)



- In 1198 Pope Innocent III called for the capture of Jerusalem.
- While the Crusaders were on their way to the Holy Land, they decided to attack and settle in Constantinople in 1204.
- The city was captured on April 13, 1204.
- All monumental structures, including Hagia Sophia, were destroyed, and hundreds of years of manuscripts were burned.
- Many valuable works were taken to Europe.
- In 1261, the Palailogos dynasty took back the city.
- However, the city became ruined and poor during this period.

- After the Latins captured the city, the Byzantine imperial family and aristocrats went to other regions.
- They established principalities there.

- Michael VIII Palailogolos took Constantinople back from the Latins, but the city was in a very bad condition and most of the Anatolian lands were lost.

- The Latin occupation was a great blow to the Byzantine Empire. The empire never found the strength to recover.

- The period from the recapture of the city from the Latins to the Ottoman conquest is the last phase of Byzantine civilization **(1261-1453).**

Periods of Byzantine art and architecture

Early period (330-726): The period from the time Istanbul became the capital and the traces of traditional Roman imperial architecture were still visible in monumental structures such as Hagia Sophia.

The period of iconoclasm-depiction (726-843): The period when depictions of humans, angels and holy people, other than geometric shapes, were not included in social life and the architecture that took shape accordingly after Christianity became the official religion, and these were destroyed.

Middle period (843-1204): The period of military and financial revival when religious architecture was shaped by the church due to the dominance of the church institution despite the end of the depiction movement.

The period of the Fourth Crusade-The First Latin Kingdom (1204-1261): The period when Catholics, mostly of Venetian origin, ruled. They seized Istanbul and established a kingdom in the city instead of serving the purpose of saving the lands considered sacred to Christianity.

The last period (1261-1453): The period also known as the Palaiologan Dynasty, which left its mark on the period and began with the Byzantine administration recapturing Istanbul after fleeing to Nicaea and shifting the administrative center there during the invasion of the Fourth Crusade.

Early period (330-726):

The period from the time Istanbul became the capital and the traces of traditional Roman imperial architecture were still visible in monumental structures such as Hagia Sophia.

- The first two centuries of the early period, roughly until the reign of Justinian (527-565), is **the "Byzantineization" of Rome**.
- **Initially, Roman culture was completely dominant. Christianity and paganism coexisted**. The official language of the state was Latin. In the Byzantine geography, Greek was used as the common language, apart from the local languages. After a while, during the reign of Heraclius (610-641), Greek became the official language of the state.
- The art and architecture of the 4th and 5th centuries also contain many elements of Ancient Roman art. However, this gradually changed, and **during the reign of Justinian, Christian culture began to predominate.**
- **Starting with Justinian, Byzantine culture would gradually move away from the Ancient heritage of Rome and develop its own originality.**
- The important threshold in this transformation was the Iconoclastic movement, which turned into a concrete policy in the early 8th century.
- Justinian's idea of establishing a "single universal Christian empire" is embodied in the extensive construction activities he undertook throughout the empire and in the Hagia Sophia that crowned this initiative. The last monumental example of the Roman architectural tradition, Istanbul Hagia Sophia proclaims to the entire world Justinian's goal: A single empire, Rome, rules the world; this Christian empire that believes in one God has a single emperor.

Early period

Hagia Sophia

is the largest church built by the Eastern Roman Empire in Istanbul and **was built three times on the same site**.

- When it was **first built**, it was called **Megale Ekklesia (Great Church)**, and from the 5th century onwards, it was defined as Hagia Sophia (Holy Wisdom). Hagia Sophia **served as the cathedral where the rulers were crowned throughout the Eastern Roman Empire** and was **the largest church in the capital.**
- **The first church was built by Emperor Constantine (337-361) in 360**. The first structure, which had a longitudinal (basilical) plan and was covered with a wooden roof, was burned and destroyed as a result of the popular uprising that broke out in 404 when the patriarch was exiled due to disagreements between Empress Eudoxia, the wife of Emperor Arkadios (395-408), and Patriarch of Istanbul Ioannes Chrysostomos. **Today, there are no remains of the first church**.
- **The second church was rebuilt by Emperor Theodosios II (408-450) in 415**. It is known that this structure had a basilical plan with five naves, a wooden roof and a monumental entrance. The church was destroyed in 532 during the great popular uprising known in history as **the "Nica Revolt",** which broke out as a result of the union of the blues representing the aristocracy and the greens representing the tradesmen and merchants against the Empire in the 5th year of the reign of Emperor Justinian (527–565).

During the excavations, steps, column bases and frieze fragments decorated with lamb reliefs representing the Twelve Apostles belonging to the Propylon (monumental entrance gate) of the Second Building, which can be seen approximately 2.00 m below the current ground, were found.

Early period

Hagia Sophia

- The present-day Hagia Sophia was built **by Emperor Justinian** (527-565) by two important architects of the period, **Isidoros of Miletus** and **Anthemios of Tralles.**
- According to historian Prokopios, the construction started on February 23, 532 and was **completed in a short period of 5 years**, and the church was opened for worship with a ceremony on December 27, 537. It is stated in the sources that **100 architects, including two chief architects, and 100 workers worked under each architect during the construction.**
- According to the sources, on the opening day of Hagia Sophia, Emperor Justinian entered the temple and said, “Thank God for giving me the opportunity to build such a place of worship,” and then went to Jerusalem to visit the Prophet. It is said that he shouted, “O Solomon, I have surpassed you,” referring to the Temple of Solomon.
- **The innovation in the architecture of the Third Hagia Sophia is the combination of the traditional basilical plan and the central domed plan**. The structure has three naves, an apse, and two narthexes, inner and outer. The length from the apse to the outer narthex is 100 m. The width is 69.50 m. The height of the dome from the ground is 55.60 m, and its diameter is 31.87 m in the north-south direction and 30.86 m in the east-west direction.

Early period

- In order to make Hagia Sophia more magnificent and showy, Emperor Justinian sent a message to all the provinces under his command and ordered the most beautiful architectural pieces to be collected for use in Hagia Sophia. The columns and marbles used in this structure were brought from the ruins of ancient cities in Anatolia and Syria such as Aspendos, Ephesus, Baalbek, and Tarsus.

Hagia Sophia

- There are a total of 104 columns in the structure, 40 of which are in the lower gallery and 64 in the upper gallery.
- All surfaces of Hagia Sophia, except for the marble-covered walls, are decorated with beautiful mosaics. Materials such as gold, silver, glass, terracotta and colored stones were used in the production of the mosaics. The plant and geometric mosaics in the structure date back to the 6th century, while the depicted mosaics date back to the period of iconoclasm (the Period of Depiction 730-842).
- **Since Hagia Sophia was an Imperial Church during the Eastern Roman Period, it was the place where the coronation ceremonies of the Emperors were held.** For this reason, the round and interlaced patterned floor covering (omphalion) of colored stones located to the right of the main hall (naos) in Hagia Sophia is the section where the Eastern Roman Emperors were crowned. During the Fourth Crusade, Istanbul was **occupied by the Latins** between 1204 and 1261, and both the city and **Hagia Sophia were looted** during this period. It is known that when the Eastern Romans recaptured the city in 1261, Hagia Sophia was in a very dilapidated state.

Early period

Hagia Sophia

- **Hagia Sophia was converted into a mosque when Fatih Sultan Mehmed (1451-1481) conquered Istanbul in 1453**. It continued its existence as a mosque with the additions of the Ottoman Period (pulpit, mihrab, muezzin gallery, sermon podium).
- **The structure, which has been damaged by various earthquakes since its construction**, had buttresses built for support during both the Eastern Roman and Ottoman Periods. The minarets built by Mimar Sinan also serve as supporting buttresses in the structure. The library built by Mahmud I, located in the interior, is also important. During the reign of Sultan Abdülmecid (between 1847-1849), extensive repairs were carried out in Hagia Sophia by the Swiss Fossati Brothers.
- During the same period, 8 calligraphy panels with a diameter of 7.5 m written by Calligrapher Kadıasker Mustafa İzzet Efendi were placed on the walls of the main space.The same calligrapher wrote the 35th verse of the Nur Sura in the middle of the dome. The exterior of the Hagia Sophia Mosque includes the baptistery, sultan tombs, fountain, muvakkithane, primary school and soup kitchen units.
- **Hagia Sophia was converted into a museum** by the order of Mustafa Kemal Atatürk and the decision of the Council of Ministers and opened to local and foreign visitors as a museum on February 1, 1935.
- **It was reopened for worship as a mosque in the near future.**

Hagia Sophia



https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=v6BAPskdJXc

Early period

Agios Ioannes Studios Monastery Church (*Imrahor Ilyas Bey Mosque*)

is the oldest religious building in the city. It was built in 454.

- The structure was named after a senator named Studios who undertook its construction, and over time, Ioannes (Yahya) was added to its name because the skull of John the Baptist was brought here.
- This monastery complex was inhabited by members of the Akoimetai (Sleepless), an important sect from the early Byzantine period. These monks took this name because they continued their rituals in shifts day and night.
- The Studios Monastery, which is not mentioned much in 6th and 7th century sources, was **suppressed during the Iconoclasm period and its monks were dispersed**.
- **The church and therefore the monastery were frequently used by state officials**.
- During the 57 years of Latin rule, many churches and monastery structures in the city were destroyed. The Studios Monastery and church also received their share of this destruction and **looting, and the roof of the structure collapsed and became dilapidated**. In addition, valuable items and sacred relics in the church were stolen. In 1261, Palaiologanos VIII took back the city from the Latins and left the Theotokos Hodegetria icon, which he believed gave him strength, to the Studios Monastery and was crowned in Hagia Sophia.
- The monastery and church, which were **devastated as a result of the Latins plundering** the city, were repaired and put back into service by Constantinos, the brother of Andronikos II, in 1293.
- **In 1486 during the Ottoman period, it was converted into a mosque by Emir Ahur** (Imrahor/Ahir Emir**) Ilyas Bey**. After it was converted into a mosque, a wall was built to create a mihrab in the direction of the qibla.

- **Agios Ioannes Studios Monastery Church (Imrahor Ilyas Bey Mosque)**





In Samatya district, in a region close to Yedikule

Early period

Hagia Irene

- **The building, one of three churches built by Emperor Constantine I in the city, bears a name meaning the Holy Peace of God.**
- Although there is no information about the orijinal plan type and architecturel features, it probably had a basilica plan like other structures of the period.
- **It was destroyed during the Nika Revolt** that broke out immediately after Justinian I ascended to the throne. It was probably rebuilt in the 6th century.
- **In the courtyard of Topkapı Palace near Hagia Sophia in Sultanahmet.**
- **It was not converted into a mosque during the Ottoman period, but it was a place where war spoils were exhibited, and later became a museum, becoming the first museum in the country.**



The period of iconoclasm-depiction (726-843)

- This period, which took its place in Byzantine history as iconoclast or iconoclasm, **literally means breaking images**.
- It is an artistic vandalism movement against the sacred images of the Christian religion, whether movable or immovable.
- The debates between the human and divine identity of Jesus in the Christian faith, the concern that icons would be perceived as idols and the emergence of those with different views among the emperors of the period, also found its echo with opposing ideas among religious scholars.
- Leon III, who also brought the patriarchs to his side, issued a decree in 730 and ordered the destruction of all depictions of saints.
- In the Council of Hieria in 754, it was emphasized that the depiction was completely satanic. These council rules and the destruction of depictions continued until the 760s, with the execution of some supporters of the depictions.

The period of iconoclasm-depiction (726-843)

- In this period, **churches are decorated only with non-religious ornaments such as crosses, plant motifs and animal figures.**
- The style that can be considered Neo-Hellenism is enriched with eastern motifs, peacocks, twin leaves and the figures in the paintings appear more elegant and perspective-oriented.
- After the death of Constantine V, the iconoclastic movement begins to lose its influence.

Middle period (843-1204)

With the end of the iconoclasm movement, the church institution was very dominant in this period, and religious architecture was shaped by the church.

In general, it was a period of military and financial revival.

- During the 200-year period of iconoclasm, monasteries that were suppressed and closed in on themselves developed Christian dogma and created innovations in architecture and painting.
- The new period was a period when monasteries left their mark on the cultural field and Christianity dominated the entire cultural field. After this period, Byzantine culture took on a "medieval" identity and in a sense gained its true personality.
- **During this period, the medieval culture shaped by Christianity was dominant.**
- Byzantine culture, which had fully digested the factors that formed it, now formed its own unique characteristics, independent of them, and emerged as a "different" culture.
- The material problem in new construction was solved by demolishing old monuments. Instead of building forums in public buildings, other development works were preferred.
- Building typology: Small churches combined with monasteries, chapels added to existing religious buildings.
- Lips Monastery - Mirelaion - Sulu Monastery and Peripleptos Church - Pantocrator Church and Monastery

- **The Monastery of Lips consists of two adjoined churches** in the Lycus valley of Constantinople, southwest of the Church of the Holy Apostles.
- **During the Ottoman Era, it became a mosque known as Fenari İsa Mosque.** The north church, dedicated to Theotokos Panachrantos (the Immaculate Mother of God), was constructed in 907 under the auspices of Constantine Lips, while the south church, dedicated to Hagios Ioannes Prodromos (St. John the Forerunner), was built in the late thirteenth century by Empress Theodora (c. 1240-1303), wife of Michael VIII Palaiologos.

- Constantine Lips was an aristocrat and military official who founded the original monastery and dedicated it to the Theotokos. It has been suggested that he restored an older church, however archaeological evidence does not support this claim.



Monastery of Lips , today Molla Fenari Isa Mosque/Fatih

- **The Monastery of Theotokos Peribleptos** was a Middle Byzantine church in the region of Psamathia (Turkish **Samatya**).

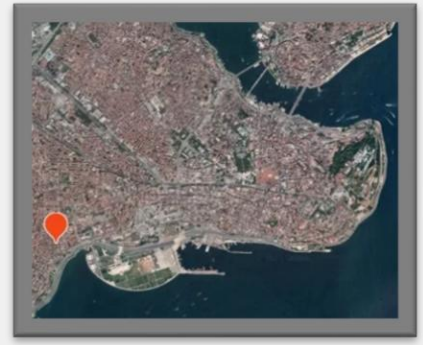
- There is a modern Armenian church dedicated to St. George (Armenian Surp Kevork) at the location now.

- Its original name Peribleptos has been variously translated as “celebrated” or “blessed”, while its Turkish name, Sulu Manastır (“Water Monastery”), refers to its holy spring (hagiasma) located southwest of the current church.

- **Though the original church was destroyed by a fire** in 1782, substructures of the 11th century church have survived



Armenian Surp Kevork Church built on the Sulu Monastery/Peripleptos Monastery and Church

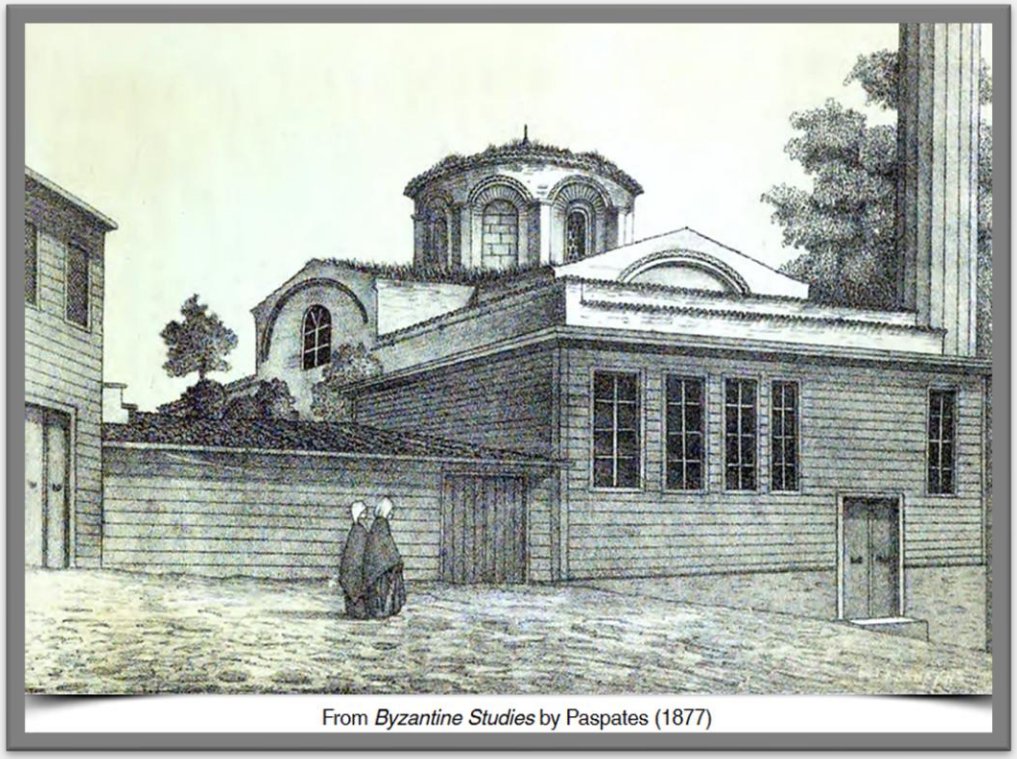


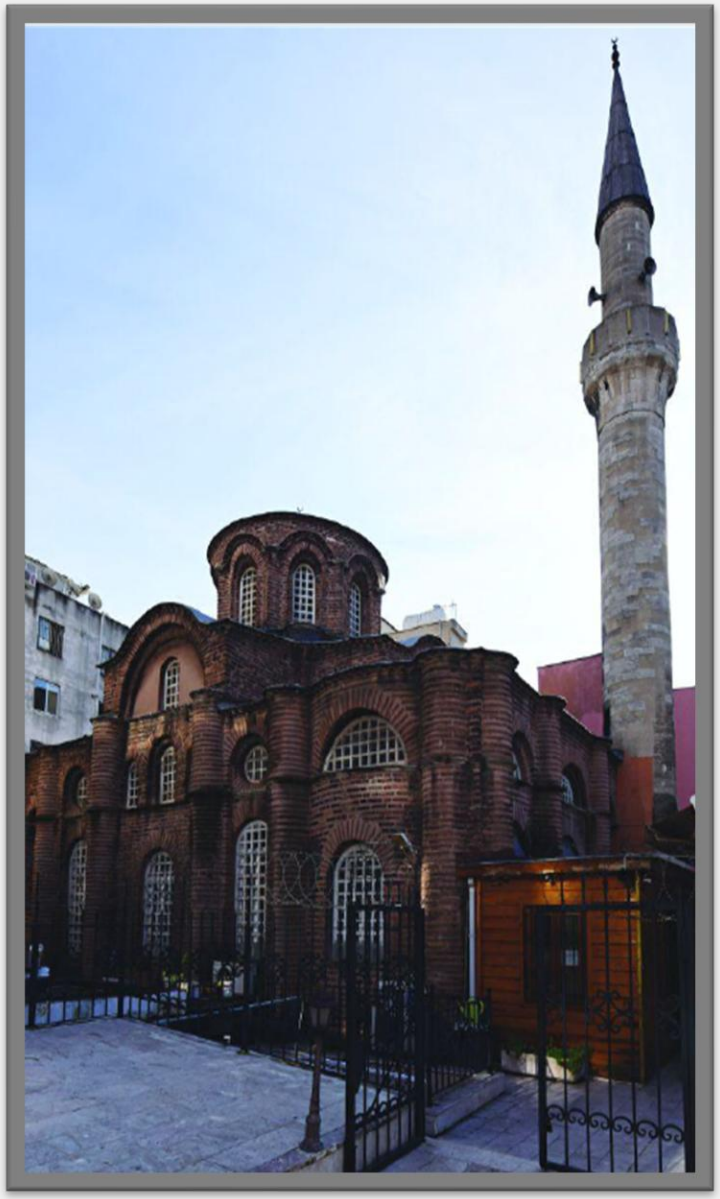
- **The Monastery of Myrelaion** (Bodrum Camii) was once located at west of the Forum of Theodosius on the Mese in Constantinople.

- It is an important example of a cross-in-square plan from the Middle Byzantine era.

- The church was constructed around 920 as a palace chapel attached to the palace of the emperor Romanos I Lekapenos.

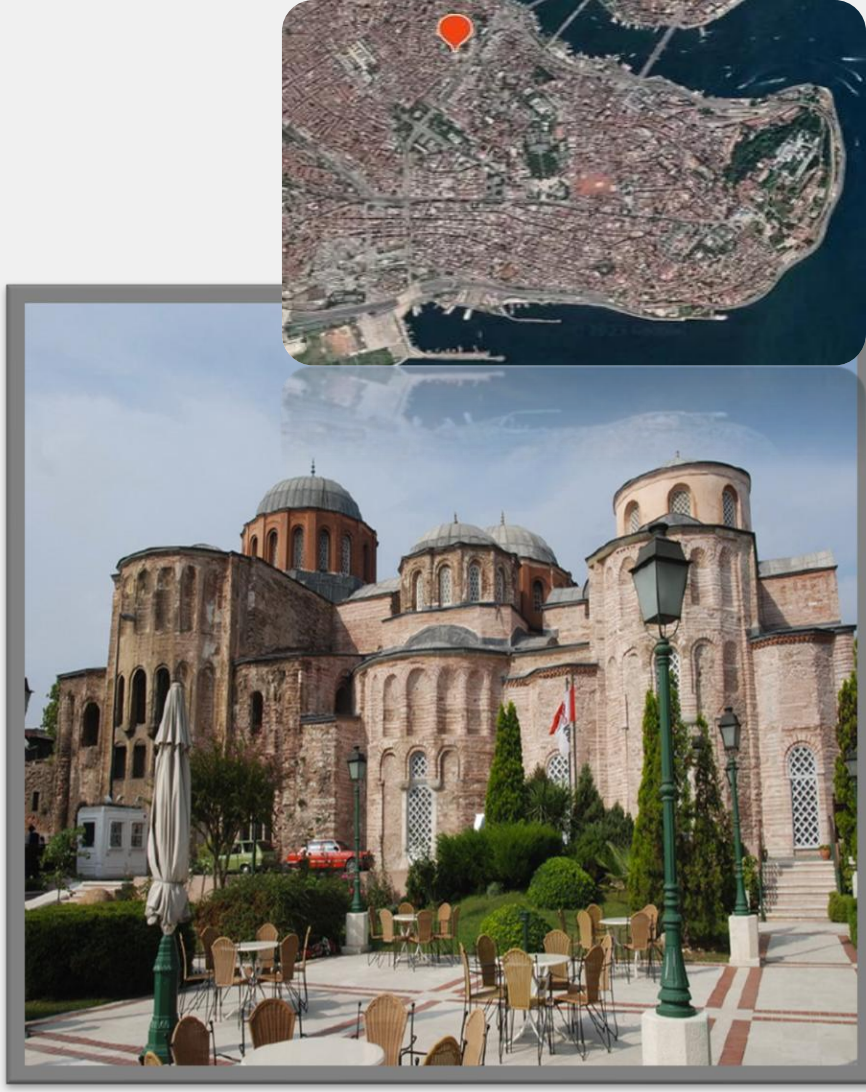






The Monastery of Myrelaion (Bodrum/Mesih Pasha Mosqe)

- Although some sources claim that the three side-by-side churches that remain from the monastery today were built by the daughter of Hungarian King Ladislas and Byzantine Emperor Irene, the general consensus is that their construction was commissioned by Emperor John II Komnenos (1118-1143).
- The Monastery of Christ Pantokrator is located on the fourth hill of Constantinople overlooking the Golden Horn, east of the Church of the Holy Apostles and north of the Aqueduct of Valens. Built between 1118-1136, it was a large monastic complex with a hospital. It is possible that the nearby Şeyh Süleyman Mosque was once part of the complex, perhaps serving as its library. There are also several cisterns in the vicinity, including the prominent is Unkapanı Cistern. At one time it held more than a dozen tombs of Byzantine emperors.
- Now known as Zeyrek Mosque, the surviving contiguous structures consist of two churches with a chapel between them. The monastery was founded by Eirene, the wife of John II when construction on the south church, dedicated to Christ Pantokrator, began around 1118.



The Monastery of Christ Pantocrator, Today Zeyrek Mosque /Fatih-Zeyrek

The period of the Fourth Crusade-The First Latin Kingdom (1204-1261):

The period when Catholics, mostly of Venetian origin, ruled. They seized Istanbul and established a kingdom in the city instead of serving the purpose of saving the lands considered sacred to Christianity.

- There is no construction activity during this period.
- During this period, Orthodox churches were converted into Catholic churches.

The last period (1261-1453)

began with the Byzantine administration recapturing Istanbul, having fled to Nicaea during the invasion of the Fourth Crusade and moving the administrative center there.

- After the Byzantines took back their cities from the Latins, they managed to revive their civilization, although not to the same extent as they had before.

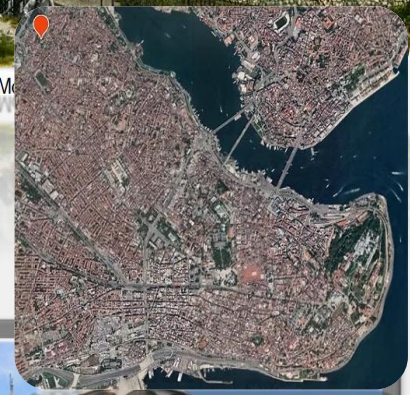
- The cultural revival seen in the capital contradicts the poor state of affairs in the empire as a whole. The upper classes living in the lost lands in Anatolia came to Constantinople and invested in culture and art.
- An elite group interested in ancient Greek culture, science and philosophy formed in the capital.

- **With a few exceptions, the empire's power was not sufficient to produce new architectural works.**

  - Chora Monastery
  - Pammakaristos Monastery and Parekklesion

- It is a church structure dedicated to Jesus and forms the center of the **Chora Monastery**, which was a large building complex during the Eastern Roman Empire.
- Since it is located outside the walls of Istanbul (Constantinos), the name Chora, which means rural area outside the city in Greek, was deemed appropriate for the building. Kariye is the Turkish version of this name.
- Although the exact date of construction of the structure cannot be estimated, it is known that it was rebuilt in the 6th century by Emperor Justiniaus (527-565) on the site of a chapel in ruins outside the city. Since it was near the Blackhernal Palace during the Comnenus Period, the church was used as a palace chapel for important religious ceremonies.
- The Monastery of Chora was located in northwestern Byzantine Constantinople near Charisios Gate (Edirnekapı), south of the Palace of the Porphyrogenitus (Tekfur Sarayı).
- The well-preserved mosaics and frescoes of the surviving katholikon of the monastery are important examples of monumental art of the Late Byzantine period.
- The structure, which was not damaged during the conquest of Istanbul, was **converted into a mosque by Grand Vizier Hadım Ali Pasha** in 1511 during the reign of Sultan Beyazıd II and a madrasah was added next to it.
- **After serving as a mosque** (known as Kariye Mosque or Ali Pasha Kenise Mosque), **it was converted into a museum in 1945 and** is now part of the Historic Areas of Istanbul of UNESCO World Heritage





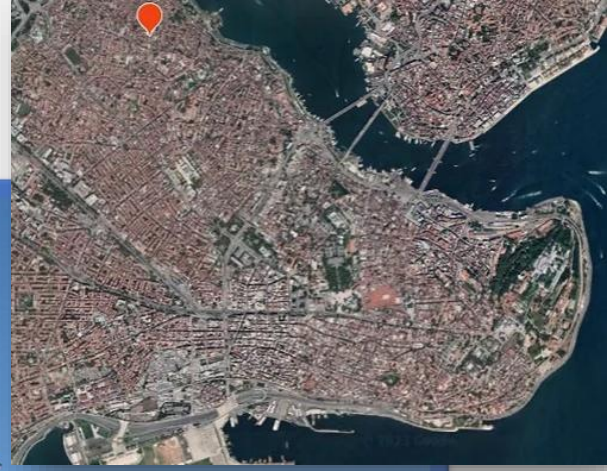


Chora Monastery, today Kariye Museum/Edirnekapı

- **Pammakaristos Monastery** is one of the most interesting historical churches in Istanbul. $

- The church building actually consists of two adjacent buildings. The main building currently serves as the Fethiye Mosque. The second building is a tomb chapel (“parakklesion”) that was added later and currently serves as a museum.





Pammakaristos Monastery (Fethiye Mosque) and Parekklesion, Today Fethiye Museum, Balat-FATİH